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The Ride



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My seven year old son Baker was one of those magnetic souls that attract people. Last summer we moved into a town with a population of just over 450. By the end of June, **everyone** knew my child. When on walks or trips to the store, I was constantly amazed as people of all ages, who I did not know, would address my son by his first name. In the summer his skin turned dark mocha brown from hours at the public pool. He was the only one in the town at his age allowed to go by himself. He was a great swimmer, a fish. He could hold his breath from one end of the pool to the other. I remember the day of his first solo trip to the pool. I went to pick him up and could not find him. I did the panicked scan of the bottom before I went to the basket house to see if any of the lifeguards had seen him. He was sitting on the lap of the pool manager playing cards. His SpongeBob Squarepants towel was wrapped around his shoulders. He looked over at me, grinning, "Hey, Dad." If I hadn't seen the birth certificate I would swear my son was a twenty- five year old. He was infatuated with girls, women actually. If they only knew what was going on in his miniature mind they would not have been so quick to put him so close to their bikini clad breast. As the summer progressed, I quickly learned right where to find Baker. His laughter was infectious. Like I said, he was just special. Everyone felt it. I would always ask him,"Hey buddy, you ready to go?" He would look up at the whatever young lady happened to be holding him that day and give a quick smile and a double eyebrow raise as if to say *Yowza, Yowza* and then would leap to the concrete floor with a slapping of bare feet. July 14th was the same as all those days up to point where I picked him up. We walked outside and hopped into the car for the six block drive home. As we were pulling into the driveway Baker suggested we go for a ride when he noticed the bikes leaning up against the side of the garage. I didn't want to go and tried to convince him he was too tired from being at the pool all day. He was having none of that. Baker was at an awkward age where he was between bike sizes. I kept wanting him to jump up to his brother's old bike so he could keep up. I was tired of always having to circle around to wait for him. Or of getting off to walk our bikes up hills. Baker had a true fear of the bigger bike but I was intent on making him grow up. His simple suggestion of a bike ride with his dad quickly turned into a argument about his need to quit being a baby. After our micro five minute verbal war where I said I would not go on the ride unless he rode the big bike, he gave in. I helped him up and gave him a push and he was on his way. We rounded the front of the house where my wife was sitting on the porch swing. Baker's beautiful little face beamed as he yelled, "Look at me mom!"

I pulled my bike up next to my wife as I watched Baker go up and down the road. He was a bit shaky, turns made in series of quick jerks, but he was getting better with each pass. My wife was not impressed , with me that is; but rather angry. "What are you doing? He isn't ready for that bike yet. What, did you do make him ride it?"

I lied, " No, he wanted to."

"Well, at least get a helmet on him. I want you to know I think this is a stupid idea." With that, she went into the house. I called Baker over to the porch. He slowed to a stop and then fell over onto his side. He was ok. My older son's helmet was in the grass next to us. So, I picked it up and told Baker that his mom said he had to put it on. He came over and I helped him snap it. A quick push later and we were on our way. Baker and I both noticed right away how much quicker we were able ride with the bigger bike. He was really starting to enjoy the speed he could achieve. At the edge of town we climbed a large hill that led down to the town cemetery. I was in front but heard the high pitched whine of tires closing in behind me. Like a flash Baker went screaming by . He must have been going around 25 miles per hour. I thought to myself , "I should tell him to slow down", but I said nothing. About a 100 yards ahead of me was a sharp left turn into the graveyard. What happened next I have played over and over in my head for the past three years. Each time seeming less and less real. Baker was going too fast to make the turn. As he pushed on the brakes the helmet came down over his eyes and the gravel slid under the tires. His bike slammed into the six inch steel pole that held the gate. The front forks on the bike snapped like dry twigs and Baker was on the ground, flat on his back, confused, legs kicking trying to get free from the entangled brake cables. It felt like an eternity before I reached my son. He was conscious. I couldn't see his eyes through his brother's helmet. He was covered with blood, crimson bubbles boiling from his mouth and nose. Something was terribly wrong with his face. It was distorted, swollen, WRONG. I undid the helmet so I could see his eyes. He was staring up at me dazed and scared." Are you all right little buddy? I tried to sound calm; I did not. He tried to talk, I saw that his teeth were shattered glass. I sat him up, holding him tight in my arms. "You're ok, you're going to be ok." I gently lifted him and started to walk the half mile back up the road to the nearest house. I walked so softly, so swiftly trying to float. Baker's eyes were locked on mine. He continued to cough up blood, my shirt and face were now sprayed red. I looked as though I too was in the wreck. I held his head up so that he wouldn't choke. My lower back was burning as I marched up the hill trying not to move my son in anyway. I looked up at the houses, they seemed to pull away from me with every step. When I looked back down at Baker he spoke, without moving his jaw, deep in the back of his throat the nearly inarticulate words, "I won't let you down dad." He closed his eyes. Panicked, I picked up the pace to the first home, running now, jarring my boy as I went. I reached the door and kicked it hard screaming, " Help, my God, someone help!" No one answered. I ran to the next house kicking and screaming. The door nearly came off the hinges. No one answered. I was frantic, Baker had not reopened his eyes. I ran across the street and kick hard, screaming hard, "HELP!" The door was jerked open. The man's face froze. Before him were two scarlet victims. I recognized him as a man who had said, "Hi" to Baker and rubbed his head yesterday at the gas station. I could tell that now, he did not recognize either of us. Without words he shoved us to his van and I let him. We raced down the road at 100 miles per hour trying to cover the 15 miles to the nearest hospital as quickly as possible. On the way I was in a haze. I know he called my wife on the cell phone. I could not talk to her. I did not want to talk with her. I knew, she knew who was to blame. I looked down at the now purple bruised face of Baker. He looked as though he was wearing a Halloween mask. If I did not know I was

holding my son I would not have known him. His eyes were still closed. I pulled him to my chest, I wanted to squeeze him as hard as I could but I only held him softly. I cannot describe to anyone who is not a parent the hole that was within me. A pain so intense, a ache, a deep incurable sickness of body, mind and soul. We arrived at the hospital and I sprang from the car, crashing through the swinging doors to the emergency room. The doctors took him from my arms and disappeared. My wife arrived ten minutes later frantic, angry. She would not look me in the eyes, would not let me touch her. After a half an hour a doctor came out and told us that they were Life Starring him to Kansas City and that one of us could ride in the helicopter. My wife went. I watched as they wheeled my boy, my Baker by on a gurney. I watched as they loaded him. I watched as they flew off. My wife had not said one word to me. I drove the three hours to the children's hospital by myself. I knew nothing of what was going on. It wasn't until alone that I allowed myself to cry. I was so guilty. Why hadn't I listened to my son, my wife. I had not cried since I was a child, and now I found that I couldn't stop. I thought of turning the wheel hard into oncoming traffic. I deserved to suffer, to die. By the time I finally arrived it was past 10:00pm. My wife saw me enter and came at me swinging her fist, hitting me in the face, "He's in a coma, he's in a coma!" My brow split, my nose bled as my hands remained at my side. As quickly as she had attacked, she turned and went back to her chair.

Three years have passed since that night. I find myself driving in the city to my wife's new house to visit my sons. As I approach the driveway I recognize the back end of the JEEP Cherokee and realize I just missed my wife's new husband heading off to take my older son to his ball practice, I will pick him up there. My wife was on the front landing and disappeared inside when she saw me, but returned before I had gotten completely out of the car. In front of her she was pushing the wheelchair of my 10 year old son, Baker. She gave me a quick glare and then disappeared into the house again. I walked up to Baker. His head was tilted to the left, his eyes unfocused as they stared into the clouds. "Hey buddy, you ready to go?" I knew not to wait for a response. "Look what I got for you." I pulled a SpongeBob Squarepants ball cap from behind my back and placed in on his head. Now, his pale skin burned easily in the summer sun. I moved behind and pushed. We went all over town, people only acknowledging us with quick uncomfortable glances. No one said, "Hi." I pushed Baker down to the city pool. We sat in the shade, silent. He couldn't smile but somehow I sensed he liked being around the splashing, the laughter of other children. The last words from my son which haunted me every night, once again echoed in my head, "I won't let you down dad." I began to cry, I find I do it easily now.

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